Venezuela: Talking Points (Grades 7-8)

Video: about 13 minutes. Use these points if the video does not play.

0. Before independence

- Indigenous peoples (Caribs, Arawaks, Timoto-Cuicas) lived here for thousands of years. Columbus reached the coast in 1498 (third voyage). 1499: Ojeda and Vespucci see stilt houses and, by the most popular story, name it "Little Venice." Caracas founded 1567. Cacao plantations relied on enslaved Africans. Captaincy General of Venezuela, 1777. Francisco de Miranda's 1806 expedition.

1. Simón Bolívar and independence

- Born in Caracas, 1783. 1810: Venezuelans challenge Spanish rule; 1811: independence declared.
- 1821: Battle of Carabobo secures Venezuelan independence. Gran Colombia joined Venezuela, Colombia, Ecuador and Panama.
- Bolívar is "El Libertador"; Bolivia is named after him.

2. Abolition of slavery

- March 24, 1854: President José Gregorio Monagas signs the law abolishing slavery. About 11 years before the U.S. (1865).

3. Cultural blend

- Indigenous, African and European traditions: arepas, joropo (harp, cuatro, maracas), African drums, Spanish with Indigenous words, mestizo identity.

4. Beauty and resources

- Angel Falls (979 m / 3,212 ft), the tallest waterfall on Earth; Andes and Pico Bolívar; Los Roques; Margarita Island; Orinoco River.
- Largest proven oil reserves in the world (about 303 billion barrels, EIA 2023); gold, iron, cacao.

5. Dictatorship to democracy

- Gen. Marcos Pérez Jiménez fell in January 1958. Democracy from 1958; decades of relative stability funded by oil.

5b. The golden age (1958-1983)

- Barroso II gusher (1922) began the oil era. 1970s "Venezuela Saudita": among the richest in Latin America per person. Immigrants from Spain, Italy, Portugal, Colombia. Ciudad Universitaria de Caracas (UNESCO). Gran Mariscal de Ayacucho scholarships (1974); El Sistema music program (1975); Miss Universe wins; baseball stars. Free elections and peaceful transfers 1958-1998. Weakness: oil dependence; Black Friday, Feb 18, 1983 (bolívar devalued).

6. Decline under Chávez and Maduro

- Chávez took office in 1999: nationalizations, price controls, concentration of power, close ties with Fidel Castro and Cuba (Cuban advisers in security and intelligence).
- Maduro from 2013: oil output fell about 70% from 2013 to 2023 (EIA), hyperinflation, shortages of food and medicine.
- 2024 election disputed: the opposition published vote records saying it won. UN investigators documented serious human rights abuses.

6b. The playbook: how power was kept (documented, attributed)

- 1999 constitution and new institutions; 2004: Supreme Court expanded from 20 to 32 justices (HRW); electoral council seen as controlled by the government; 2007: RCTV license not renewed (HRW: politically motivated); 2009: term limits removed by referendum; 2017: Smartmatic, the voting-technology company, said turnout for the Constituent Assembly vote was inflated by at least one million votes (Aug. 2, 2017; the electoral council called the claim baseless); expropriations of businesses and farms.
- Critics and the UN Fact-Finding Mission: food boxes (CLAP) tied to loyalty; armed pro-government groups (colectivos); mass arrests and political prisoners (2014, 2017, 2024); UN found crimes against humanity (2020) and that Cuban agents advised military counterintelligence (2022 report). Compare: Cuba has been one-party since 1959.

7. The diaspora

- Nearly 8 million Venezuelans have left (UNHCR, based on government figures); about 7.0 million in Latin America and the Caribbean (R4V, Aug 2026).
- Destinations: Colombia (largest), Peru, Brazil, Chile, and the U.S., especially Florida. Families are separated.

8. Maduro captured

- January 3, 2026: U.S. forces captured Maduro and his wife in Caracas. Southern District of New York: narco-terrorism conspiracy, cocaine-importation conspiracy and weapons charges (indicted 2020); superseding indictment unsealed Oct. 8, 2026 adds conspiracy to commit torture, including the torture of U.S. citizens (DOJ press release, Oct. 8, 2026). He is in U.S. custody awaiting trial. Delcy Rodríguez is interim president.
- UN Independent International Fact-Finding Mission on Venezuela: crimes against humanity, including torture, enforced disappearances, extrajudicial killings and political imprisonment. UN human rights office: more than 5,000 killings by security forces in 2018 (OHCHR). U.S. officials say Hezbollah supporters operated in Venezuela; the Treasury sanctioned some in 2008.

9. María Corina Machado and what is next

- Won the opposition primary (2023); barred from the 2024 ballot; Nobel Peace Prize 2025.
- Returned to Venezuela on October 25, 2026 (her night arrival in Caracas is embedded on the web page) after almost ten months abroad.
- No official election date. Machado asks for 2027 (a July 24, 2027 date has been proposed); U.S. officials want the Supreme Court and electoral council reformed first. Say: "elections are expected in 2027."

Discussion questions

- What does independence mean, and why did Bolívar fight for it?
- Why do people leave their country, and what do they take with them?
- What makes free and fair elections important?

Sources: Reuters, AP, Congressional Research Service (Jan 2026), U.S. EIA, UNHCR / R4V, World Bank. Prepared Oct 28, 2026.